

What's summer without some sexy swimwear? **RANNA GILL** (right) and **RINA DHAKA** created **BIKINIS** for bodacious babes while **SAVIO JON** and **MALINI RAMANI** brought back the romance in resort wear.

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was only a handful of clear-cut trends that emerged on the catwalks. One could sense the presence of an evolved design dexterity proving that Indian couturiers are becoming intelligently individualistic. Most garments were positively deceptive, being effortlessly easy on the eye. They were all about sophisticated deconstruction. Think of it as complex simple, a twist in sobriety. The frockfest continued in sensuous and sharp silhouettes. Some flattering, some flirtatious and some fitted. Jersey, chiffon, blends, cotton, lace and linen were haute favourites. Designers also remained true to texturing. Pratap's pin tucks and pleats were flawless, his play between opacity and transparency a sheer delight. Nitin Bal Chauhan experimented with organic fabrics. Debutant designers Pankaj & Nidhi Ahuja had an outstanding show, which included intricate ornamental cutwork jackets in bright colours. International influences were inherent. While Chauhan did his own rendition of Gladiator shoes, Goel's heavy petal jumpsuit took off from Stella McCartney's version, while her flapper dresses were very Balenciaga. Sadly, her one-shouldered earthy-hued dress looked like Pocahontas gone wrong while Bhartia's band-master like waistcoat was very similar to Alexander McQueen's recent India-inspired collection. Local muses too were at play. Anjana Bhargav's radically refreshing collection made one wonder if she might have hired an assistant who interned at Gaurav Gupta's studio. Vikram Phadnis' saris, dresses in tie and dye, leheriya prints, brocade panels and dorie ensembles were shockingly good considering his previous work and highly reminiscent of Anamika Khanna and Sabyasachi Mukherjee.

Menswear mavericks like **CUE** put out **JUMPSUITS** (above), while **BAHL** made linen suits. **RATHORE** and **VALAYA** sent out jodhpurs, while **SHANTANU & NIKHIL** created Lhama wraps.

Tradition with a twist. **PRIYADARSHINI RAO** reinterpreted the angarakha, **ANAMIKA KHANNA** (right) did **CHURIDAR PANTS** with voluminous kurtas while **VIKRAM PHADNIS** created ethnic Indian wear and Indo-western outfits.

HEMANT CHAWLA

In menswear, squarely constructed shoulders gave way to softer lines. Menswear mavericks put out jump suits (Cue), linen shirts (Priyadarshini Rao), linen suits (Varun Bahl), jodhpurs (Raghavendra Rathore, Valaya) and Lhama wraps (Shantanu & Nikhil). Think of it as the maturity of masculinity.

Arora's circus-themed wIFW finale, artfully choreographed by Aparna Behl and Tanya Lefebvre—with a parade of pieces that seemed like an installation on heels—seemed a fitting tribute to the madness of the week, and the scrapping between the two camps continued till the end. "The FFI is a mistake. The dates were decided by irresponsible people intentionally when our schedule came out," says Sethi. Nair is nonchalant. "We felt the same way when wIFW and LFW started in 2006. Now we are used to it. So give this time to settle down as well," he says. We would. If only designers weren't pitched against each other, and the shows were smartly spaced at venues located adjacent to each other. "It is not about gimmicks and promises. It is about substance, longevity and credibility that comes with experience," adds Sethi. After all, it's about the survival of the fashion industry, not a body, claim both FFI and FDCI. Then it shouldn't be a problem. Surely, they can compromise in the name of couture. But for now, wIFW and LFW felt like a vanity fair fuelled by enormous egos. It was filled with sound and flurry that signified nothing but just another day to play dress up. ■

